Australian Government
Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water

Interview preparation guide



Image credit: Lachlan Wyatt

The big picture

Be prepared

Our experience shows candidates who spend the time preparing well for their interviews consistently outperform those who don't prepare – even if they are potentially a stronger match on paper.

Preparation for an interview is critical. Nobody is so experienced that they don't require significant preparation for each interview they attend. Preparation for interview is not a quick flip through the potential employer's website and job specification.

Careful preparation for your interview will:

- lead to less nerves at interview
- increase your capacity to describe your experience in a structured, professional manner
- help you to relax in your interview and focus on listening and understanding questions
- allow you to better understand your next career move and will help you avoid making incorrect career choices
- maximise your chance for a successful interview.

Feel free to bring notes including any specific questions you need answered – this sort of preparation will be seen as an indicator of a strong potential hire for the employer.

Think about your audience

Critical to your preparation is understanding or predicting the needs of your audience.

Put yourself in their shoes

The interviewers are trying to uncover 3 key things:

- Can you do the job? Do you have the necessary skills, qualifications and experience?
- What is your motivation for doing the job? What is your attitude to work and what are your career goals?
- Will you fit into the team? Is there a culture match? Will you be someone they will enjoy working with? Are you someone that presents as a 'risk' to the harmony of their current team?

If you are prepared to answer these questions in your interview and can do it in a structured manner with relevant examples, you are heading towards becoming the preferred candidate.

Do your research

The best way to understand your audience is through thorough research. Your research should focus on:

- Who is your audience? What is their role? Where do they fit into the organisation? What are their professional backgrounds?
- What are they looking for? What are their expectations for the role?
- Why does the organisation need the role?

- What is the context surrounding the vacancy?

Personal and professional networks

Find out more about your potential employer and interviewers by calling and speaking with those most likely to be in the know.

Know your CV and career

Know your 'story' inside and out. Think through your experience and be able to articulate how you have come to this point in a manner that is positive and logical.

Be able to clearly articulate your own motivations and goals including for:

- previous job or career changes
- what you enjoy doing most and why; what motivates you
- what work you prefer doing and why.

It sounds counter-intuitive but knowing your work experience intimately is key to your success at interview. Rarely does everyone remember their past work experiences off by heart, and even more rarely are they able to describe these experienced with a structured, logical manner.

The world is at your fingertips online

We are often blessed with a huge amount of information online about local organisations particularly public sector organisations. Organisation websites, media releases, annual reports, published business plans...Google is your best friend when it comes to preparing for interviews.

Take advantage of this plethora of information so you can go into your interview with eyes open. But remember, the web is only one source of information – it is risky to rely solely on the internet for interview preparation.

Understand the job specification and selection criteria/core competencies

Study the job duties and prepare questions about aspects of the role that are not clear to you.

Draw parallels with examples from your own experience to each part of the job/criteria, and prepare detailed examples to demonstrate your competencies in performing these duties.

For roles where the critical requirements of the position are in a list of selection criteria or core competencies, it is essential you:

- prepare detailed examples relating to each criterion or competency using the STAR model
- know the selection criteria you wrote well
- steer interviewers to positive outcomes you have generated through your work with well chosen, targeted examples.

Be on time and know where you are going

Be 100% sure of the time, date and location of the interview and research travel times, public transport or parking well in advance. Always make sure you come to the interview 'armed' with all

relevant contact details ‘just in case’. This includes who will be there, their positions in the organisation, their phone numbers etc.

Any more than 10 minutes early is too early – if you arrive too early wait in the car or take a short walk to calm yourself. Anything later than the agreed interview time can be a black mark against your chances at interview.

Practice and rehearse

Practice your interview responses answers and consider running a ‘mock interview’ with a friend or colleague just as you would when preparing a presentation or similar.

Prepare specific responses to commonly asked questions

There are a wide range of commonly asked interview questions that when prepared for, can allow you to concentrate on more difficult questions or on building rapport with the interviewers. Remember, just because the questions are common and ‘about you’ it does not mean they will be easy to answer so preparation is vital. And again, don’t forget to exemplify your responses.

Tell us about yourself...

Although this seems a simple question, many people find this one very difficult to respond to appropriately. Prepare a response as it is easy to get carried away and present a lot of irrelevant personal information or to ramble.

Your answer to this question needs to be specifically targeted to the job, selection criteria and the organisation.

- Set a framework – aim for three key points that have led you to this point in your career.
- Briefly convey a sense of who you are, and where you are going.
- Mention your previous career and how this prepares you for the role you are interviewing for (qualify with concrete examples, don’t go through a chronological history).
- Present just enough detail without getting into a lengthy autobiography. Two minutes is a good rule of thumb for this question.

Strengths and weaknesses

There are many ways interviewers assess how your interpretation of your strengths and weaknesses.

Strengths

- How would your referees describe you?
- What accomplishments are you most proud of?
- What achievements define your career to date?
- What will you bring to our organisation?
- What specific skills are you most proud of?

Remember to focus on providing a mix of personal and technical strengths – we recommend preparing a minimum of five overall with detailed examples to support your statements. Avoid self-qualifying statements. If it is a strength explain why referring to previous examples of how this strength has led to positive performance outcomes benefiting previous employers.

Make sure you:

- target your strengths to the role you are interviewing for
- avoid self-qualifying statements / self-affirmations if they are not supported by evidence
- provide a breadth of responses (e.g. not all personal strengths).

Weaknesses

- What weaknesses are there in your performance to date?
- Where do you feel you could improve your performance?
- In your last performance review what were the key areas for development raised?

When describing weaknesses, it is best to give only one or two examples. Describe your weakness as point for development you have identified, perhaps with the help of a previous manager, and describe constructively how you seek to address this. The interviewers are keen to see you demonstrate self-awareness and emotional maturity/intelligence. Honesty is always the best policy but make sure you frame your response in a positive or constructive light.

Remind them that when you identify a problem, you actively take actions to correct it, and that is how you do things.

Avoid answering with:

- cliché's like "I am a workaholic", "I take on too much", or "I am a perfectionist".
- listing a weakness that discounts your suitability for the core competencies of the role (e.g. "I am not strong with detail" if you are going for an accounting role)
- "I don't know..."

Other questions you may be very likely to be asked at interview include:

- What are your long- and short-term goals? What motivates and interests you?
- Why are you interested in this job? Why are you suitable for it?
- Why did you leave your last job?
- What do you know about our organisation/team?

Make sure you are prepared for these standard questions as a minimum.

Behavioural and situational questions

The theory behind these kinds of questions is that your past performance is the best predictor of future achievements. These types of questions require you to give specific examples of work situations to illustrate your previous performance or behaviour. They are meant to be tough to answer and require significant preparation to answer them well.

Typically, these questions commence with:

- Tell me about a time when…
- Can you give me an example of when you have…

Following the initial prompting question, they are often followed up with guided prompts to steer you towards providing an answer that meets the requirements.

Typical prompts include:

- What action did you take?
- What were you responsible for?

- What were the consequences? What was the result?

This style of interview questioning can be used to assess any of the core competencies required for a particular position.

A useful approach to structuring your response to behavioural questions is the STAR model. Structure your response around the following points:

- Situation – describe the circumstance where you used the skill and gained experience.
- Task – what was your role?
- Action – what did you do and how did you do it?

Result – what did you achieve? What was the outcome and how does it relate to the role you're applying for?

Do's and don'ts and curveballs

Don't:

- "oversell" yourself or embellish the truth.
- complain about / criticise former employers or managers – be careful here.
- over-answer questions. Keep answers informative but relatively brief. Monitoring your interviewer's body language will give you clues as to whether you are talking too much.

Interview curve balls

Inexperienced interviewers

Prepare for inexperienced or nervous interviewers. Remember, many interviewers do not interview people regularly and many are not naturally very good at it. Often a short interview results from an inexperienced or unskilled interviewer rather than the candidate. By preparing questions and being able to volunteer structured information about your experience relevant to an opportunity you can help guide an interview without momentum to your advantage.

Nerves or not at your best

If despite all your best preparation and effort you are still very nervous, let the interviewer(s) know up front by plainly stating that: "I am experiencing some nerves and please excuse me until I am warmed up."

Do not continue apologising throughout the meeting as this will create a lasting negative impression.

If you are ill and you still attend your interview, let the interviewer(s) know in advance so they are aware.

Finishing the interview

Aim to leave a positive impression by:

- being genuine and professional, but not overly familiar
- confirming your interest in the role and why – remember, many people are successful because they are clearly highly motivated to win the role

- addressing any possible shortcoming noting your awareness and putting a positive slant on this
- leaving the interviewer(s) with a strong impression of you – take the time to thank all attendees.